🌻 Focus or exclude factors

📅 22 Sep 2025

Summary

This extension is about using **factor labels** to carve out a useful subgraph of your causal map.

Like most extensions, it is best thought of as:

1. **A filter** (a rule that takes one links table and returns another), plus
2. **An interpretation rule** (what it means to say we are "focusing on" or "excluding" factors).

There are two closely related operations:

- **Focus**: keep the causal neighbourhood around one or more "target" factors (their upstream causes and/or downstream consequences).
- **Exclude**: remove unwanted factors (and therefore remove any links that touch them).

Unlike label-rewrite transforms (collapse synonyms, remove bracket text, zoom hierarchies, combine opposites), focusing/excluding does **not** rename factors. It decides which parts of the existing graph you want to *see and analyse*.

Syntax (the conceptual parameters)

Focus

- **Target factor labels**: one or more label patterns defining the focus set F
- **Matching rule**: exact vs substring (and similar "match modes"); matching is case-insensitive in the current app
- **Upstream steps** U and **Downstream steps** D: how far to look back/forward along causal chains
- **(Optional) Source tracing**: require that a kept path can be realised within a single source (single-narrative constraint)

When multiple focus patterns are supplied, they are treated as **OR**: anything matching *any* pattern becomes a target in F.

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Exclude

- **Excluded label patterns**: one or more patterns defining the excluded set E
- **Matching rule**: exact vs substring, etc. (also case-insensitive in the current app)

In the current app, multiple exclusion patterns within one exclude step are combined with **AND**; to express "exclude A OR exclude B" you use multiple exclude steps.

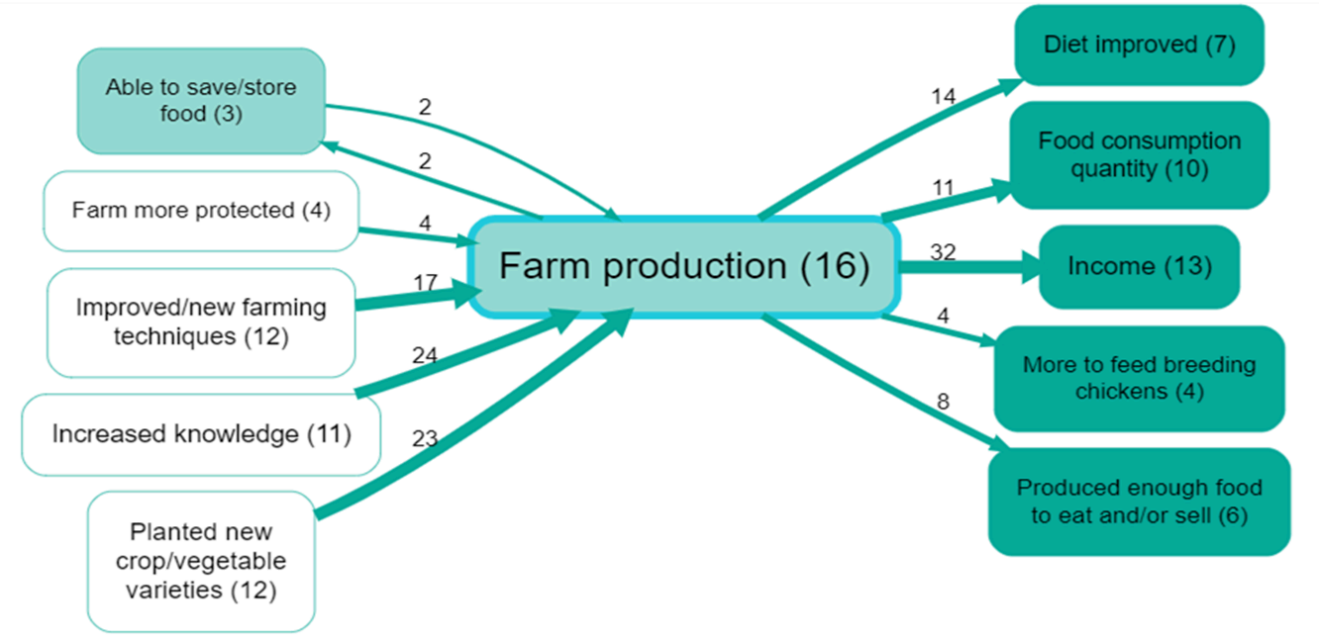
1) The filter: links-table semantics

Both focus and exclude ultimately operate by selecting rows of the **links table** (one row per coded causal claim), producing a new links table L'. All downstream views (maps, tables) are then derived from L'.

Focus = neighbourhood extraction

Focusing is not "keep only these factors"; it is "keep only the links that sit on bounded-length paths to/from these factors".

Focusing helps you understand a factor as both an **outcome** (what leads to it?) and an **influence** (what follows from it?), without having to interpret the entire map at once.



Step limits define which links are kept

Let F be the set of focused factor labels.

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The intended definition is **link-based** (not factor-based):

- Keep a link $x \to y$ if it lies on **any path of length** ≤ U that **ends** at some focused factor in F , **or** on **any path of length** ≤ D that **starts** at some focused factor in F.
- Do **not** then add extra "cross-links" between the factors that happen to survive. (The output should contain only links that are actually part of the selected upstream/downstream paths.)

In interview-style data, causal chains longer than ~4 steps are uncommon; choosing U, D is therefore a modelling assumption about how far a "story" typically extends.

"Source tracing" as a conservative interpretation

Sometimes you want paths that reflect *single-source narratives* rather than a composite chain stitched together across sources.

In source tracing mode, a factor/link is only kept if there exists **at least one path** satisfying the upstream/downstream rule where **every link segment comes from the same source**.

Exclude = remove incident links

Excluding is subtractive: you specify excluded patterns E, and **any factor that matches is removed**, along with any links incident to it (as cause or effect). Equivalently: remove all links $x \to y$ where $x \in E$ or $y \in E$.

2) Interpretation rules and modelling cautions

Order matters

If you apply label-rewrite transforms earlier in your pipeline (collapse, zoom, remove brackets, combine opposites), then focus targets are interpreted in terms of the **rewritten labels** produced by those transforms. Conceptually: you are focusing on the map *after* those normalisations.

Focus is a reading strategy, not a claim about reality

Focusing is a way to make a large map interpretable by restricting attention to a bounded neighbourhood. It does not assert that the shown neighbourhood is the only relevant one; it asserts that "within U, D steps, what do respondents say connects to F?"

Relationship to "collapse" (different goal)

- Use **collapse/label-rewrite** when you want to treat several labels as *the same concept* while keeping the surrounding structure visible.

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- Use **focus** when you want to keep the original labels but restrict attention to the local causal neighbourhood of a concept.

Examples (contrasts) from the app

The same focus, with vs without zoom (order matters)

These two bookmarks focus on the same concept ("Farm production") but differ because one applies **zooming** (hierarchy roll-up) and the other does not:

- No zoom: bookmark #805
- Zoom level 1: bookmark #806

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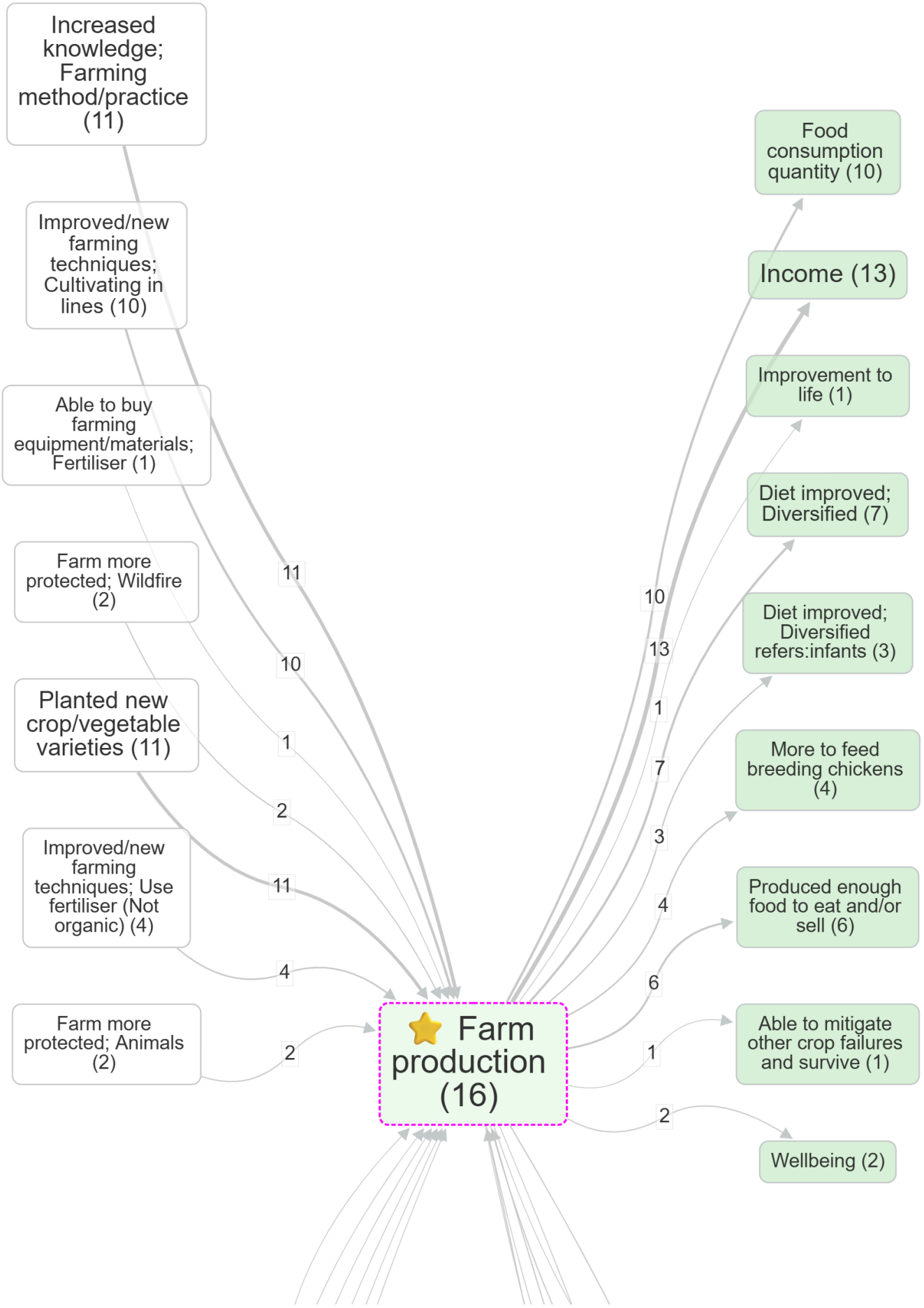

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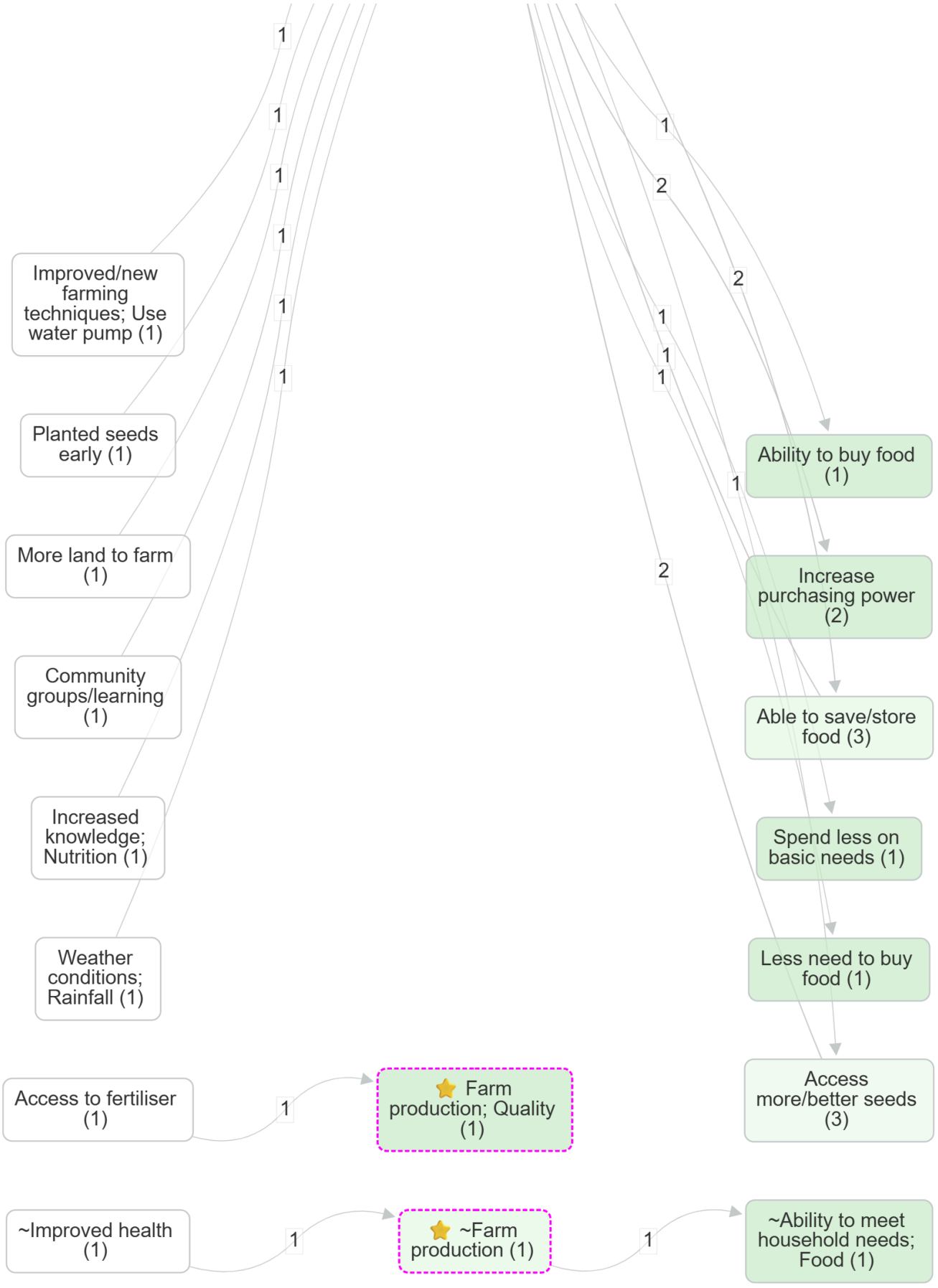

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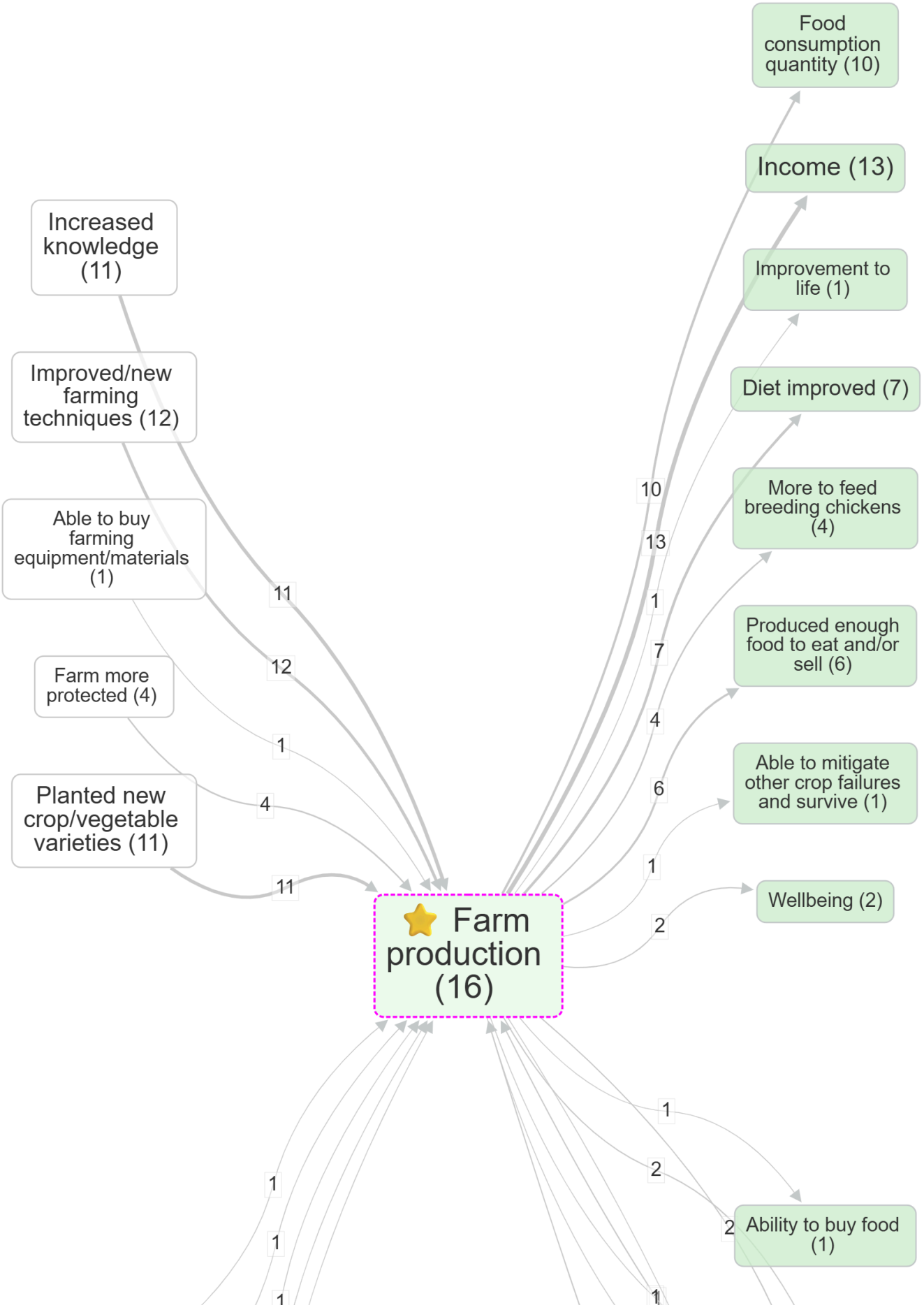

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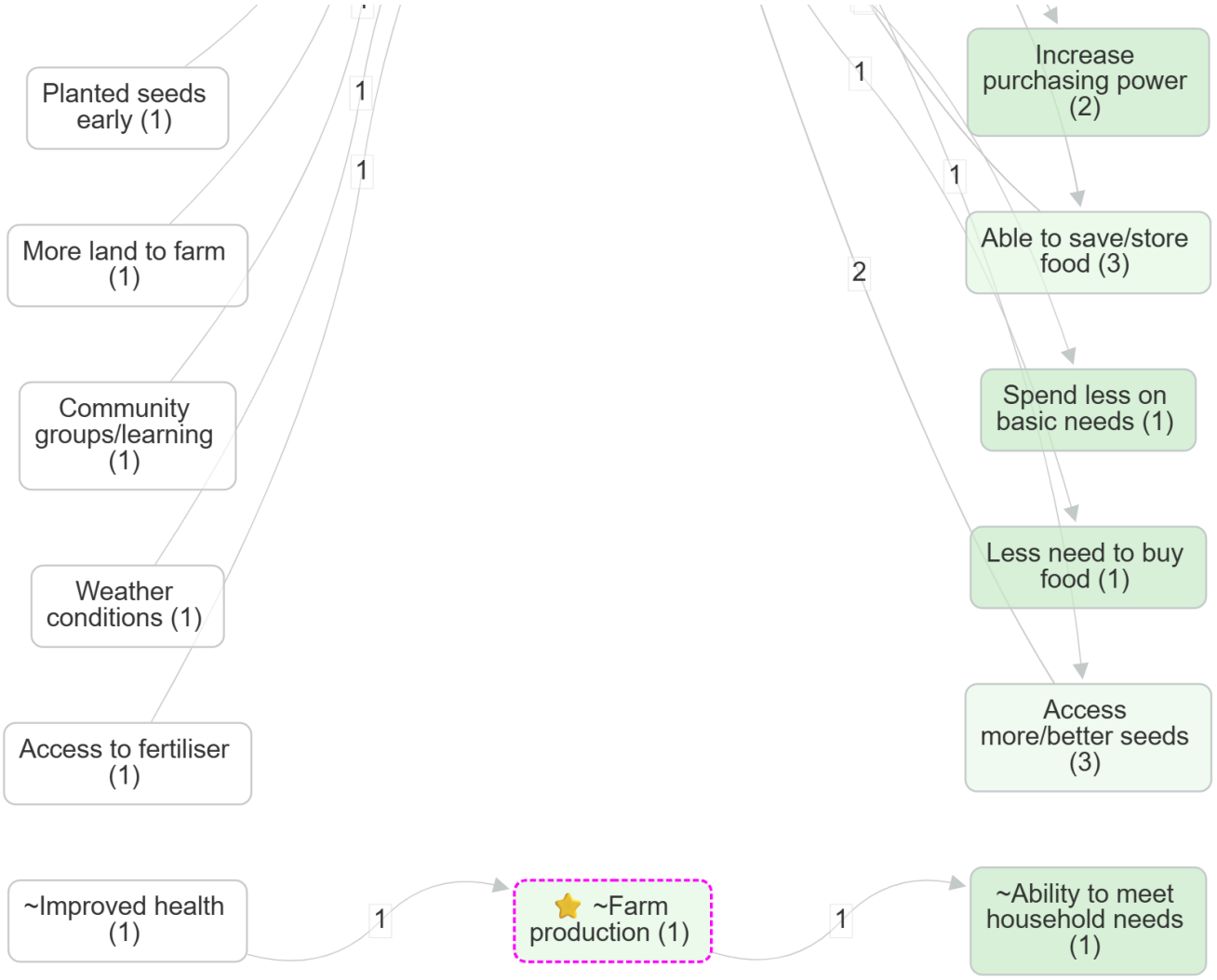

A single-theme focus (one-step neighbourhood)

Bookmark #982 is a simple example of focusing on one theme and looking at its immediate neighbourhood.

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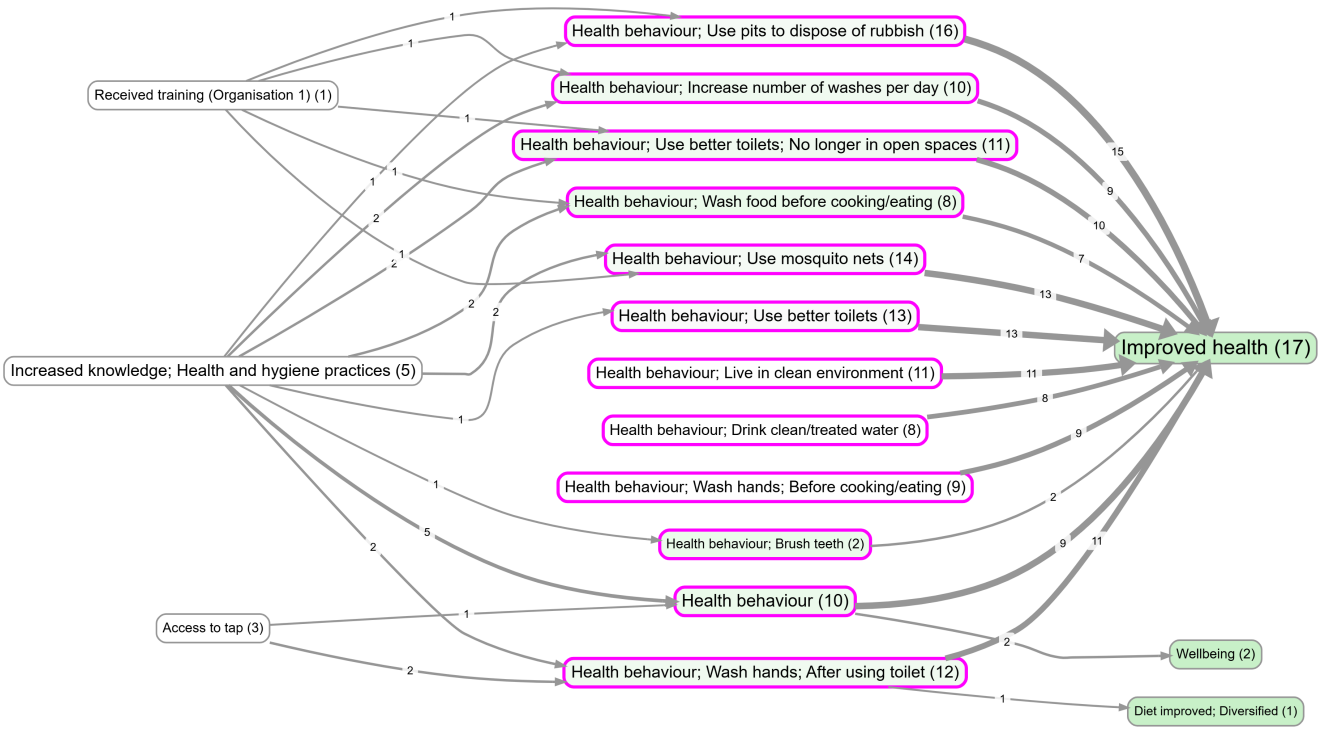

Upstream focus with a single-source constraint ("source tracing")

These two bookmarks are both "upstream influences on wellbeing" views, but one requires within-source narrative coherence:

- Without source tracing: bookmark #270
- With source tracing: bookmark #534

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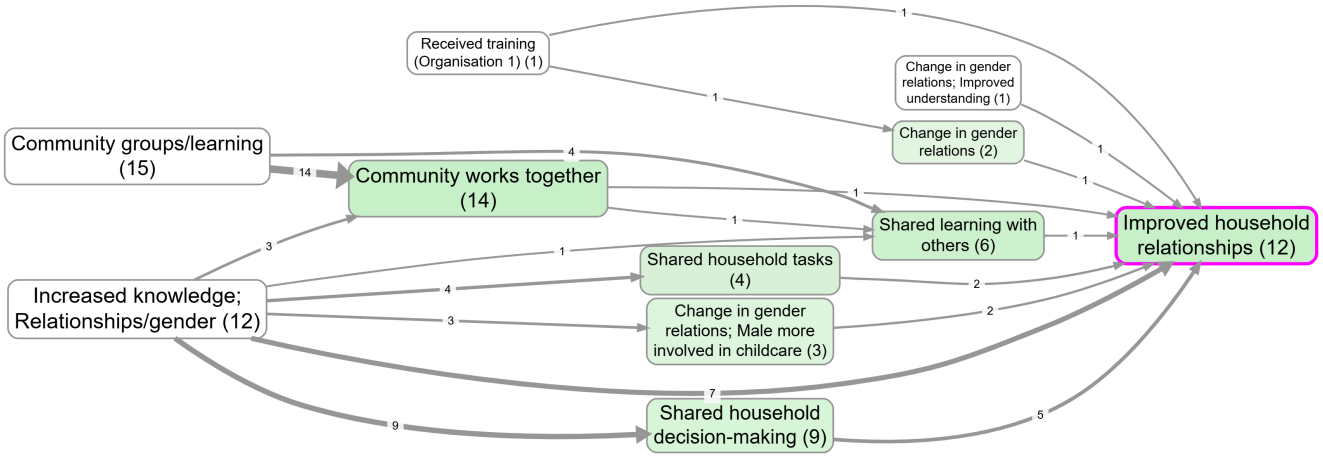

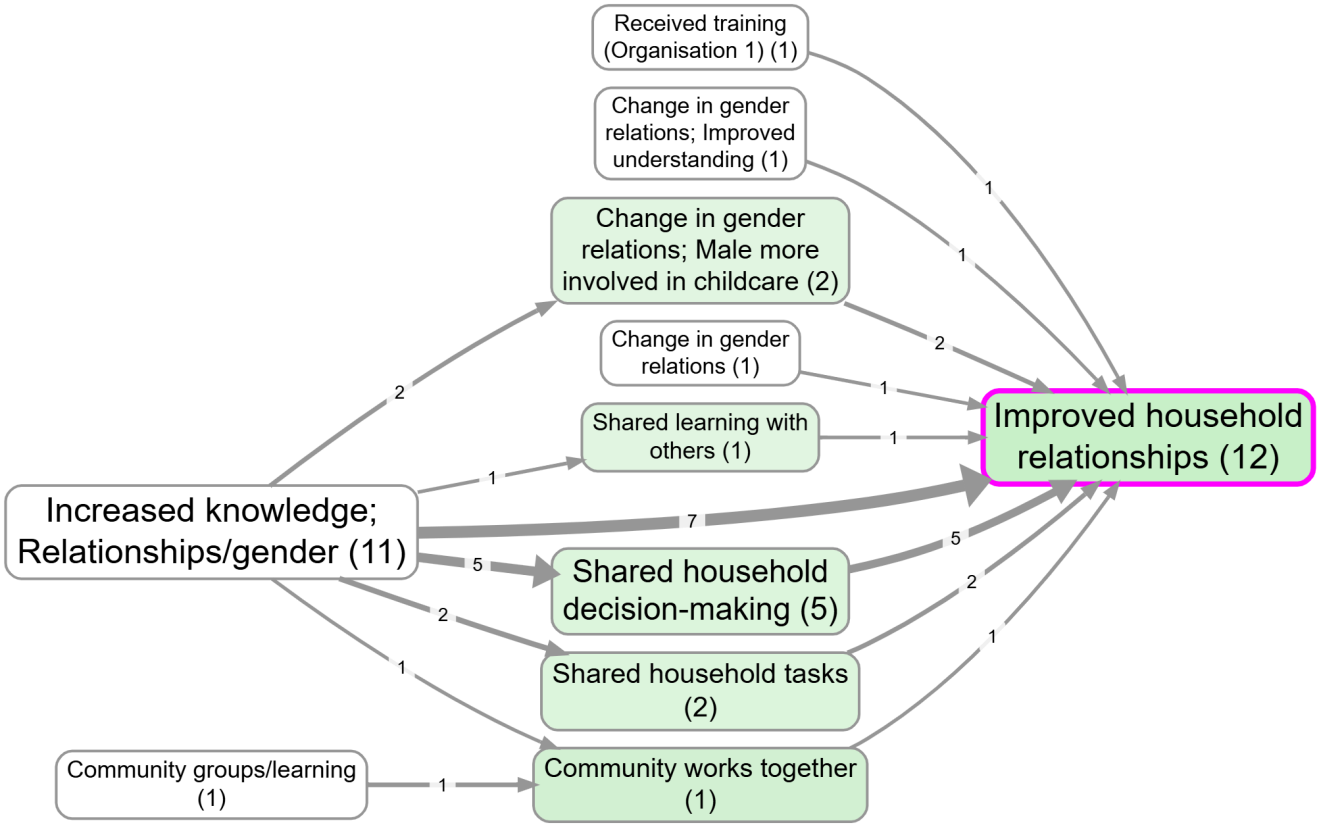

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